

Proposal: Student-Run Grocery Co-op at the UTSU Student Commons

Submitted by: Regenesis UTSG

Proposed Location: Ground Floor, University of Toronto Students' Union Student Commons

Overview

Regenes UTSG is a student-led environmental organization at the University of Toronto focused on developing community-based sustainability initiatives that support food access, waste reduction, and student wellbeing. Such programs include the At-Cost Farmers' Market, Free Stores, Borrowing Centre, campus food programming, among others.

Regenes UTSG is seeking approval and space allocation within the UTSU Student Commons to establish a student-run, non-profit Grocery Co-op, beginning in the 2026-2027 school year. The co-op will provide affordable, healthy, and sustainably sourced groceries to students. A grocery co-op is a community-oriented, non-profit grocery model that prioritizes affordability, accessibility, and sustainability over profit. The Grocery Co-op will build upon the success of the existing Regenes x UTSU At-Cost Farmers' Market. Similar campus grocery co-op models already exist at universities such as Concordia University and UC Berkeley.

Regenes UTSG has prior experience operating student-focused food programming, including running a campus food centre and coordinating regular food access initiatives through the At-Cost Farmers' Market. This experience has provided operational knowledge in food distribution, inventory coordination, volunteer management, and student outreach. **Regenes** UTSG also maintains existing relationships with food suppliers, community organizations, and produce distributors through its current programming, helping support reliable sourcing and affordable pricing for the Grocery Co-op.

Why This Matters

Rising grocery and housing costs, combined with limited access to affordable healthy food on campus, continue to impact students; particularly commuter, low-income, first-generation and international students. The Grocery Co-op seeks to bridge the gap between emergency food support and full-priced retail grocery stores by providing affordable staple foods, fresh produce, and low-waste shopping options within an accessible community-focused space.

The co-op would offer fresh produce, staple groceries, and bulk foods such as grains, legumes, pasta, nuts, and seeds, alongside plant-forward and ethically sourced products. These staple items would be subsidized to help maintain affordability for students facing financial barriers and rising food costs. A grocery pre-order system, proposed operating hours of Monday–Friday from approximately 11:00 AM–7:00 PM (with potential for expansion), and volunteer and paid employment opportunities for students would help ensure accessibility and engagement.

The Grocery Co-op would operate under **Regenes** UTSG's existing governance and operational infrastructure, supported by student volunteers, 3–4 paid student staff, and one full-time manager. **Regenes** UTSG already maintains stable levy funding and general liability insurance coverage of \$5 million. Our chapter at York University is also working on developing a grocery co-op in the First Student Centre, demonstrating broader demand for student-led food access initiatives across campuses.

Importantly, **Regenesis UTSG** intends to work collaboratively with the UTSU to support and complement the existing Food Bank rather than replace it. The Grocery Co-op is envisioned as an additional layer of food support that increases access to affordable groceries while helping reduce pressure on emergency food resources.

Regenesis UTSG is requesting consideration for the former Food Bank room on the ground floor of the UTSU Student Commons. The location is ideal due to its accessibility, visibility, and existing infrastructure for student services, and would support shelving, refrigeration, dry storage, and checkout infrastructure necessary for the operation of the Grocery Co-op.



Photos: (Top) Anabel's Grocery, a student-run grocery co-op at Cornell University; (Bottom) the Student Food Collective, a student grocery co-op at University of California, Berkeley.